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The Curious History of Cats

Cats have been curled up by our sides for thousands of years. How did it all begin?

By Talia Cowen |

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Learning Objective: to synthesize key ideas from two nonfiction articles

Complexity Factors

Lexiles: 930L, 750L

Featured Skill: Synthesis
(<https://scope.scholastic.com/>)

Other Key Skills: text structure, identifying main ideas and details, supporting and contrasting thinking

Common Core Standards

TEKS Standards

The Story

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Presentation View

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The Curious History of
Cats

Lexile® measure

930L

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Reading Level
(750L)

Nonfiction

The Curious History of Cats

Cats have been curled up by our sides for thousands of years.
How did it all begin?

By Talia Cowen

Picture a cat. Imagine chubby cheeks. Big eyes. Soft fur. Right now, you're probably going, *Awww!*

But for much of human history, thinking about cats made people go, *AHHH!* That's because most felines prowling Earth could be deadly to humans: saber-toothed cats with 11-inch fangs, roaring lions with sharp claws, fierce tigers with lightning-fast reflexes.

So how did we get to today, when millions of Americans have invited cats to share our homes (and our laps)? How did the cat go from fearsome predator to the *purrfect* pet?

The Rise of Farming

To answer that question, let's travel back 10,000 years into the ancient past. Our planet was just coming out of the Ice Age, a period when huge slabs of ice covered much of the world. In the area that is now the Middle East, warming weather led people to discover something important: Seeds could be buried in soil, grown into plants, then cut down and eaten.

Today we have a name for this system of sowing, growing, and harvesting food: farming. And the rise of farming changed the course of history. It meant humans didn't have to constantly pack up all their belongings and trudge from place to place to hunt and forage for their next meal. They could begin to settle down, and form villages and towns. It also meant they had more free time to make art and music. In

short, they could create civilizations.

As farmers became more productive, they were able to grow enough food during the warm months to keep people fed the whole year—even during the lean winter months, when it was harder to harvest. But storing surpluses of food, like wheat and barley, created a problem: It attracted hungry mice. And eventually, these nibbling rodents attracted another creature, one that loved to snack on them: cats.



The British Museum (hunting); Shutterstock.com (Bastet)

Cats were treasured in ancient Egypt. People worshipped the goddess Bastet, who often appeared as a cat. This wall painting, which shows a man hunting with his cat, was found in the tomb of an Egyptian official.

From Wild to Mild

Fortunately, the cats that hung around ancient farmers' dwellings in search of rodents weren't lions or tigers. They were wildcats, the much smaller and less aggressive cousins of lions and tigers. And the wildcats that spent time around people were even less aggressive than other wildcats.

Sometime between 9,000 and 10,000 years ago, early farmers must have figured out that these relatively docile creatures provided the important service of keeping stored food safe from pests. Some of those farmers likely started leaving out scraps of meat to make sure the wildcats would come back. Cared for by humans, the wildcats living on farms survived for longer than their wild counterparts.

When the tamer farm-dwelling wildcats mated, they produced even tamer kittens. As time went on, each new litter of kittens was tamer than the last. This process, called domestication, slowly changed wildcats into calmer, friendlier creatures. In other words, wildcats stopped being so wild and became more like, well, cats.

Humans soon realized that these felines could do more than protect food. In East Asia, cats prevented rodents from chewing up important documents. In ancient Egypt, cats chased away dangerous snakes and kept pesky birds from pecking at grain fields.

By the early 1600s, cats had spread to nearly every corner of the planet. This was a time when huge ships were sailing around the world. Merchants and military commanders alike would bring cats on board to keep food—and their crews—safe from rodents and the diseases they spread. Cats also provided much-needed cuddles and laughs on long, dangerous voyages.

When the ships docked onshore, some of these cats trotted off and made new homes. Indeed, that's how domestic cats made their way to North America.



Ann and Steve Toon/Alamy Stock Photo (African wildcat)

Scientists think most pet cats came from one type of wildcat found in Africa and Asia called *Felis silvestris lybica*, or the African wildcat. This type of wildcat is still found across Africa today.

Good Companions

Eventually, people started to think of cats more as companions than protectors. For a long time, though, only the very wealthy could afford to feed and care for a pet. That changed in the mid-1800s after the industrial revolution. Thanks to this period of rapid scientific and technological development, the wealth of many Americans increased. More people could afford to add cats to their households. And many began treating their cats like family.

Companies soon began manufacturing goods that made owning a cat even easier. In the 1930s, the first scratching posts were created so cats could be kept in the home without them shredding the furniture with their claws. Premade cat food also appeared on store shelves, which made feeding cats more convenient. And by 1950, the first kitty litter products hit the market. Now pet cats could stay by our sides all day without turning our homes into smelly messes.

Today cats are the second-most-popular pet in America. Millions of us

just can't get enough of our precious kitties. We love to pet, pamper, and cuddle them—and post adorable clips of them on TikTok.

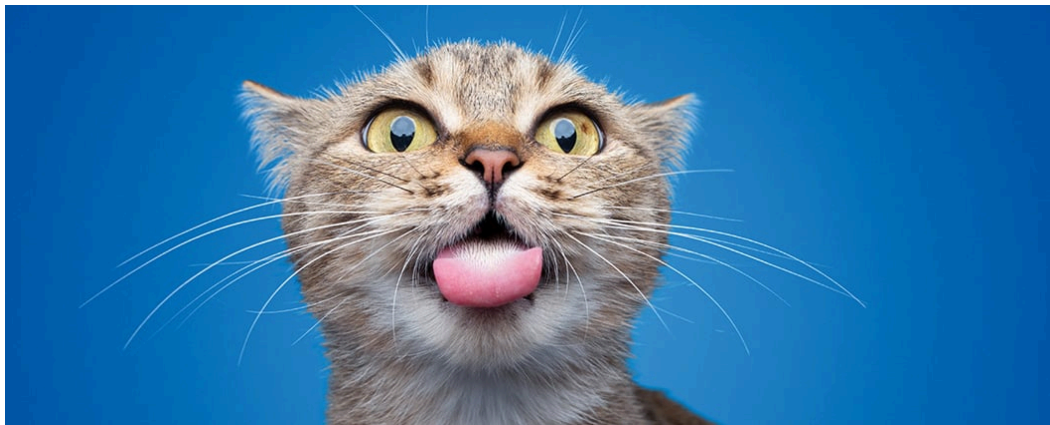
So the next time you watch a cute cat video, think about how it all began about 10,000 years ago, with a wildcat chasing a mouse on a farm.

Nonfiction

Why We Love This Weirdo Cat

Cat videos are wildly popular on social media. But . . . why?

By Jennifer Dignan and Adee Braun



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You're staring at your phone, watching a TikTok of an orange kitten scarfing down its dinner while happily meowing. You should be working on your history paper, but—oh look! A compilation of cats knocking things over. Why do they do that?! You keep scrolling. *Awwwww*. These two tabbies are sleeping on each other!!!

Suddenly an hour has passed, and you've done nothing but watch a bunch of cats being . . . cats. And you don't even have a cat! In fact, you

don't even like cats all that much. Why can't you stop watching these furry creatures? Is there something wrong with you?

No—not at all. Most of us have probably spent more time scrolling through silly cat content than we'd like to admit. After all, cats are all over our feeds. Every day, about 90,000 cat videos are uploaded to YouTube. A 2015 study in the psychology journal *Computers in Human Behavior* found that people are more than twice as likely to post a picture or video of a cat online than they are to post a selfie. As anyone who has ever seen Instagram sensation Nala Cat wearing a knit hat will tell you, there is something about cat content that we just can't resist. But what is it?



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Research has shown that watching videos of cats can improve our mood.

The Cute Factor

It might seem like the answer is simple: Cats are cute. And it's true—cats *are* cute, with their big eyes, little noses, and soft, cuddly bodies. Of course we want to stare at them for hours. But the reason we find these features so cute and irresistible is that our brains associate them with babies, defenseless creatures that humans are wired to love and protect. And the same instinct that draws us to babies also draws us to cats. In other words, it's only natural that we'd gravitate toward cat content.

Cats are far from the only cute creatures on social media, though, so there must be other reasons why they rule the internet. One of these is, no doubt, the deep connection that we share with them. Cats are among the most popular pets in the world; Americans alone own some 74 million of them. That's nearly one cat for every four people in the U.S.!

The strong and loving relationship between cats and humans goes all the way back to ancient times. In some societies, cats were even worshipped as divine creatures. In ancient Egypt, for example, the cat-headed goddess Bastet was one of the most beloved deities, and the punishment for killing a cat was often death! Beloved cats were even turned into mummies and buried alongside pharaohs in their tombs. Perhaps this deep love and admiration for cats that took root so long ago became somewhat of a cultural tradition over time, with our love for cats getting passed down from generation to generation. And now part of that tradition is showing love to cats not just in person but on our screens as well.



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Mysterious and Elusive

Another reason for the popularity of cat videos and memes is that cats are mysterious. It's often hard to tell what they may be thinking or feeling. In fact, scientists have found that most humans are pretty bad at reading a cat's facial expressions. Oftentimes we end up assigning our own human feelings and emotions to them. Assigning human

characteristics or emotions to animals is called anthropomorphizing, and we love to do it with cats—mostly because it makes us laugh. Consider the famous “polite cat” meme. Why is this cat making this face? Is he trying to smile? Is he looking for treats? Who knows! But the photo has become one of the most popular memes of all time. It’s been shared thousands of times with different captions.

Cats are also elusive. Dogs we see all the time—walking down the street, playing in parks. Many cats, however, live indoors and are rarely seen by anyone but their owners. Even our own cats are unlikely to entertain us on demand; cats are known, after all, for their independence. So we turn to social media, where we can watch them do cute, funny stuff whenever we want.

What’s more, dog owners have a special space to get together and talk about their pups: the dog park. Most cat owners can’t bring their cats outside to meet other cat fans. So they go to social media to connect over their purring friends.

Certain videos may also give a sense of satisfaction to those who feel snubbed. Ignore me when I call you? Walk away when I want to pet you? Well, ha! You just fell into a fish tank!

Chances are, though, that most of us would be happy to cuddle the cats we see online, to hold them on our laps and pet them as we stare at our phones . . . watching more cat videos.



Writing Contest



Explain how the relationship between cats and humans has changed over time. Your response can be in the form of a comic, an essay, a slideshow, or a poem. Entries must be submitted to **Cat contest** by a teacher, parent, or legal guardian.* Three winners will each get a copy of *Crenshaw* by Katherine Applegate.

**Entries must be written by a student in grades 4-12 and submitted by their teacher, parent, or legal guardian, who will be the entrant and must be a legal resident of the U.S. age 18 or older. See Contest Page (<https://scope.scholastic.com/pages/scope-contests.html>) for details.*



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